

MANUALLY OPERATED REPEATING RIFLES (1906–16)

By the end of the 19th century, bolt-action repeating rifles were in almost universal military use, but each country sought to refine and improve its own rifle. France, for example, replaced the outmoded Lebel rifle with a more modern, but still flawed, design in the form of the Berthier. The British Lee-Enfield Mark I rifle was shortened to make it handier. Although France and Britain planned more refined smaller-caliber rifles, the arrival of World War I meant that the standard caliber of .303in was retained. Even before the outbreak of war in 1914, however, the trend was toward shorter-barreled rifles.



FULL VIEW

▲ SMLE MARK III

Date 1907

Origin UK

Barrel 25¼in (64cm)

Caliber .303in

A shorter version of the Lee-Enfield Mark I (see p.148) had been introduced in 1904 as the Short Magazine Lee-Enfield (SMLE, often nicknamed "Smellie"). The SMLE Mark III introduced improvements to the rear sight, magazine, and chamber.

Rear sling attachment

Cocking piece enabled the action to be safely cocked and uncocked manually if necessary

Integral five-round box magazine

Wooden butt

Butt screw

Experimental 20-round removable box magazine

Bolt handle

Bolt

Trigger guard

Detachable 10-round box magazine

Wooden butt

Bolt handle